

Turn Your Knitting Into Income

Sell your handmade pieces — pricing, craft fairs, Etsy, packaging, and your first sales

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SECTION 1

Is Selling Right for You?

Honest questions to ask before you turn your hobby into a side business

Not everyone who knits wants to sell — and that is perfectly fine. This section helps you decide whether selling fits your life, your goals, and your temperament.

Why It Can Be Great

- Earn back the cost of your yarn (and then some)
- Share your craft with people who truly appreciate handmade work
- Set your own hours — knit when you want, sell when you're ready
- Build a creative identity beyond "just a hobby"
- Connect with a community of makers and buyers

What to Watch Out For

- Deadlines and custom orders can drain the joy out of knitting
- Pricing handmade work fairly is harder than it looks
- You'll spend real time on photos, listings, shipping, and bookkeeping
- Not every piece will sell — rejection is part of the game
- Scaling too fast can lead to burnout

Self-Assessment Checklist

- ☐ I can finish projects on a schedule, not just when I feel like it
- ☐ I'm comfortable setting a price and standing behind it
- ☐ I have at least 5–10 finished pieces I could sell today
- ☐ I'm willing to learn basic photography and write product descriptions
- ☐ I can handle someone not buying (or not loving) my work
- ☐ I have a few hours a week beyond knitting time for business tasks
- ☐ I understand I'll need to track expenses and income

If you checked most of those boxes, selling is worth trying. If not, there's no rush — keep knitting for pleasure and revisit this later.

SECTION 2

Pricing Your Work

A clear formula so you never undersell your time or materials again

The single biggest mistake new sellers make is pricing too low. This section gives you a repeatable formula and the confidence to charge what your work is worth.

The Core Formula

COMPONENT	HOW TO CALCULATE	EXAMPLE (SCARF)
Materials	Yarn + notions + tags. Use cost per skein × skeins used.	\$14.00
Labor	Hours to knit × your hourly rate (start with \$15–20/hr)	6 hrs × \$15 = \$90.00
Overhead	10–15% of (materials + labor) for tools, packaging, fees	\$15.60
Wholesale Price	Materials + Labor + Overhead	\$119.60
Retail Price	Wholesale × 2 (standard markup)	\$239.20 → round to \$239

Don't Underprice Yourself

Selling a scarf for \$30 when it took you 6 hours to knit means you earned less than \$3/hr after materials. Even if you're "just starting out," low prices train buyers to expect handmade work for fast-fashion prices. It's better to sell fewer items at fair prices than to burn out filling cheap orders.

Markup Examples by Item

ITEM	MATERIALS	HOURS	WHOLESALE	SUGGESTED RETAIL
Dishcloth	\$3	1.5	\$28	\$12–15*
Baby hat	\$5	2	\$40	\$35–45
Chunky cowl	\$18	3	\$70	\$70–90
Cabled scarf	\$14	6	\$120	\$120–150
Sweater	\$45	30+	\$550+	\$300–500*

**Dishcloths and sweaters often sell below full formula price. Dishcloths work as low-cost entry items; sweaters may need a "market rate" adjustment. Know your floor and never go below materials + a reasonable hourly rate.*

SECTION 3

What Sells Best — Top 20 Items

Ranked by how easy they are to sell, not just how easy they are to knit

Focus your limited selling time on items buyers actually want. This list is based on what consistently moves at markets and online shops.

#	ITEM	PROFIT MARGIN	DEMAND	TAGS
1	Baby hats & booties	High	Very high	Gift Quick knit
2	Chunky cowls	High	High	Seasonal Trendy
3	Headbands & ear warmers	Very high	High	Quick knit Seasonal
4	Dishcloths (sets of 3)	Medium	Very high	Everyday Entry price
5	Fingerless mitts	High	High	Gift Seasonal
6	Coffee cup cozies	Very high	Medium	Quick knit Impulse buy
7	Scarves (simple patterns)	Medium	High	Seasonal Classic
8	Beanies	High	High	Unisex Year-round
9	Baby blankets	Medium	High	Gift Premium
10	Pet sweaters	High	Growing	Niche Trendy
11	Market bags / totes	Medium	Medium	Everyday Eco
12	Slippers / house socks	High	Medium	Gift Cozy

#	ITEM	PROFIT MARGIN	DEMAND	TAGS
13	Mug rugs / coasters	Very high	Medium	Quick knit Home decor
14	Stuffed toys (amigurumi-style)	Medium	High	Gift Kid-friendly
15	Shawls / wraps	Medium	Medium	Premium Statement piece
16	Scrunchies	Very high	Medium	Quick knit Impulse buy
17	Christmas stockings	High	Seasonal peak	Seasonal Custom
18	Throw pillow covers	Medium	Medium	Home decor
19	Wrist warmers	High	Medium	Seasonal Quick knit
20	Laptop / tablet sleeves	Medium	Growing	Niche Modern

Start With the Top 5

You don't need 20 products. Pick 3–5 items from the top of this list, perfect them, and build inventory before branching out. A focused shop looks more professional than one with one of everything.

SECTION 4

Craft Fairs and Markets

Your fastest path to real-world feedback and your first cash sales

Craft fairs let you test prices, see what catches people's eyes, and practice talking about your work — all in one afternoon. They're the best classroom for a new seller.

Preparation Steps

- 1 **Find local events.** Search for craft fairs, farmers' markets, and holiday bazaars in your area. Church fairs and school fundraisers are often free or very cheap to enter.
- 2 **Apply early.** Popular fairs fill up months ahead. Read the rules — some require handmade-only goods or ban certain categories.
- 3 **Calculate your booth cost.** Table fee + supplies (tablecloth, display racks, signage, bags, change). Aim to bring enough inventory to cover the fee three times over.
- 4 **Build inventory.** Stock 30–50 items across 3–5 price points. Have plenty at the low end (\$10–20) for impulse buys.
- 5 **Price everything clearly.** Use tags or a visible price list. Buyers won't ask — they'll just walk away.
- 6 **Prepare your payment method.** Accept cash and card. A simple phone-based card reader costs little and pays for itself at the first fair.

Booth Setup Checklist

- ☐ Clean tablecloth (solid color that doesn't compete with your work)
- ☐ Risers or crates to create height variation on the table
- ☐ A sign with your shop name (hand-lettered or printed, not a loose piece of paper)
- ☐ Price tags on every item
- ☐ Business cards or small flyers with your shop name
- ☐ Mirror (if selling wearables — people want to try hats and cowls)
- ☐ Cash box with change (\$40–50 in small bills and coins)
- ☐ Card reader, charged and tested
- ☐ Bags or tissue paper for wrapping purchases
- ☐ A notebook to track sales and jot down customer feedback
- ☐ Water, snacks, and a chair — you'll be there all day

Day-Of Tips

- **Arrive early** to set up without rushing.
- **Stand up and greet people.** A simple "Hi, everything here is hand-knit" is enough. Don't hover.
- **Let people touch the work.** Texture sells knitting better than any pitch.
- **Note what gets picked up most** — that's your best seller, even if it doesn't sell today.
- **Offer bundled pricing** at the end of the day: "Take any three dishcloths for \$30."
- **Track every sale** (item, price, payment method) so you know your real numbers.

Pricing Display

Create a simple sign listing your price ranges by category. Buyers scan booths quickly — a visible price board invites them to stop and look rather than assume everything is out of their budget.

CATEGORY	PRICE RANGE	EXAMPLES
Small gifts	\$8–15	Dishcloths, cozies, scrunchies
Accessories	\$25–50	Hats, mitts, headbands
Statement pieces	\$70–150+	Cowls, scarves, shawls

SECTION 5

Selling on Etsy

Set up a shop that works for you while you knit

An online shop lets you sell around the clock without renting a table. This section walks you through setup, search optimization, photography, and writing listings that convert.

Setting Up Your Shop

- 1 **Pick a shop name.** Short, memorable, and easy to spell. Avoid puns that only make sense out loud. Check that the name isn't already taken.
- 2 **Write your shop bio.** Keep it personal: who you are, how long you've been knitting, what makes your pieces special. Two to three sentences is plenty.
- 3 **Set your policies.** Processing time (be honest — account for your knitting pace), shipping methods, return policy. Clear policies prevent disputes.
- 4 **Create your first 5 listings.** Don't wait for a "full" shop. Five well-photographed items are better than twenty with phone snapshots.
- 5 **Set up shipping profiles.** Weigh a sample item in its packaging. Use calculated shipping or build shipping into your price — both work.

SEO: How Buyers Find You

Etsy search is keyword-driven. Use all 13 tags on every listing. Think like a buyer: "chunky knit cowl," "baby shower gift," "merino wool scarf." Put the most important words in the first few words of your title. Don't waste tags on your shop name or words already in the title — Etsy reads those automatically.

Photography Basics

- **Natural light only.** Photograph near a large window during daytime. No flash.
- **Plain background.** A white poster board, a clean wood surface, or a simple fabric. Nothing distracting.
- **Show scale.** Put the item on a person, a mannequin form, or next to a common object so buyers understand the size.
- **Multiple angles.** Front, detail of the stitch pattern, the label or tag, and the item in use. Aim for 5–7 photos per listing.
- **Edit lightly.** Adjust brightness and white balance so colors look true to life. Don't over-filter.

Listing Template

TITLE

Primary keyword + description + material — e.g., "Chunky Knit Cowl, Merino Wool Neck Warmer, Winter Scarf"

DESCRIPTION STRUCTURE

- Opening line: what it is and who it's for
- Materials and dimensions
- Care instructions
- Shipping and processing time
- A brief note about handmade variation ("Each piece is made by hand; slight variations are part of what makes it yours.")

TAGS (USE ALL 13)

Mix broad terms ("knit scarf") with specific ones ("cable knit cowl") and occasion tags ("gift for her," "winter accessory"). Use all lowercase — Etsy isn't case-sensitive, but consistency helps you stay organized.

SECTION 6

Packaging and Presentation

The unboxing is part of the product — make it count without spending a fortune

Good packaging turns a purchase into an experience. It doesn't need to be expensive — it needs to be thoughtful.

For Markets and In-Person Sales

- Kraft paper bags — inexpensive, clean, and recyclable
- A small printed tag tied to each item with your shop name
- Tissue paper in a color that complements your work
- A hand-stamped "Thank You" card or sticker

For Shipping (Online Sales)

- Poly mailer or small box — choose based on item fragility
- Wrap the item in tissue paper before placing it in the mailer
- Include a care instruction card (washing, drying, storing)
- A brief thank-you note — handwritten if you can manage it
- Optional: a small extra (a stitch marker, a scrap-yarn sample)

Branding on a Budget

You don't need custom boxes or printed ribbon. A simple rubber stamp with your shop name, a consistent tag design, and a signature color of tissue paper create a recognizable brand. Buy supplies in bulk — a roll of 100 kraft tags costs less than a single skein of yarn. The goal is consistency: every package should feel like it came from the same place.

Care Labels

Include washing instructions with every item. Buyers who ruin a hand-knit piece in the washing machine aren't coming back. A simple card that says "Hand wash cold, lay flat to dry" protects both your work and your reputation.

Presentation Upgrades That Cost Almost Nothing

- **Belly bands:** A strip of cardstock wrapped around a folded item (like a dishcloth set) with your shop name and fiber content. Print at home, cut with a paper trimmer.
- **Hang tags:** Punch a hole in a business card-sized tag, loop it through the item with a short piece of yarn. Include the fiber, care instructions, and your shop name.

- **Gift-ready wrapping:** Offer to wrap items in tissue and a ribbon at no extra charge. Buyers love skipping a step, especially around holidays.

SECTION 7

Getting Your First 10 Sales

Concrete actions to go from zero to your first real customers

The hardest part of selling isn't making the product — it's making the first sale. These tactics focus on action, not theory.

Actionable Steps

- 1 **Tell everyone you know.** Post on your personal social media that you're selling. Your first buyers will be people who already know and trust you.
- 2 **Offer a "friends and family" soft launch.** Give a small discount on your first 5 sales in exchange for honest feedback and (if they're willing) a review or photo.
- 3 **Do one craft fair.** Even a small one. In-person feedback is worth more than weeks of guessing what might sell online.
- 4 **Gift strategically.** Give a piece to someone who will wear or use it visibly. When people ask "Where did you get that?" — that's free marketing.
- 5 **List at least 10 items online.** More listings mean more chances to appear in search results. Shops with fewer than 10 items look like they might not be serious.
- 6 **Photograph one item beautifully.** Make it your hero piece — the one you'd show if someone asked "What do you make?" Use it as your shop banner and first social media post.
- 7 **Join a local maker group.** Other sellers share fair recommendations, supplier tips, and moral support. You don't have to figure this out alone.
- 8 **Follow up after every sale.** A simple message thanking the buyer and hoping they love the piece leads to repeat buyers and word-of-mouth referrals.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

- **Waiting until everything is "perfect."** Your shop, your photos, and your inventory will improve over time. Start with what you have.
- **Pricing too low to "attract" buyers.** Cheap prices attract bargain hunters, not loyal customers. Price fairly from the start.
- **Making 50 of the same item before testing demand.** Make 3–5, see if they sell, then make more.
- **Ignoring the business side.** Track your costs and time from day one. If you don't know your numbers, you can't know your profit.
- **Comparing yourself to mass-produced goods.** A hand-knit scarf is not competing with a factory scarf. You're selling craft, time, and uniqueness.

SECTION 8

Scaling Up — Beyond the First Month

Where to go once you've proven people will pay for your work

You've made your first sales. Now the question is: how much bigger do you want this to get? This section helps you decide — and plan accordingly.

Comparing Your Selling Channels

CHANNEL	STARTUP COST	ONGOING EFFORT	REACH	BEST FOR
Craft fairs	Low–Medium	High (each event)	Local	Testing, feedback, cash flow
Etsy	Very low	Medium	Global	Steady passive sales
Instagram / social media	Free	High (consistent posting)	Variable	Brand building, direct sales
Consignment in local shops	Free	Low	Local	Hands-off local presence
Your own website	Medium	Medium–High	Global	Full control, no platform fees
Wholesale to boutiques	Low	Medium	Regional	Volume sales, fewer transactions

Growth Checklist

- ☐ I know my top 3 best-selling items and can make them efficiently
- ☐ I have a system for tracking expenses, sales, and inventory
- ☐ I've set a monthly income goal (even a modest one)
- ☐ I restock my best sellers before they run out
- ☐ I have a consistent look across my packaging, tags, and photos
- ☐ I've asked at least 5 past buyers for a review or testimonial
- ☐ I've explored at least one new selling channel beyond my first
- ☐ I have a "no" list — custom orders or products I won't take on

When to Say No

Growth doesn't mean saying yes to everything. Protect your time and your craft:

- **Custom orders that lose money.** If someone wants a complex piece for less than your materials cost, decline politely.
- **Rush orders.** Unless they're willing to pay a rush fee, your schedule is your schedule.
- **Products you don't enjoy making.** If you dread filling an order, drop it from your shop. Resentment shows in the work.
- **Scaling beyond your capacity.** If orders are piling up and you're losing sleep, raise prices or close your shop temporarily. Burning out helps nobody.

The goal isn't to become a factory. It's to share your craft on your terms, earn what your work is worth, and keep knitting something you love.

Next Step

Pick one item from the Top 20 list, price it using the formula, and make three of them this week. That's your test batch. Sell them — at a fair, online, or to someone you know — and use what you learn to plan your next move.